



Lost Dogs Ayrshire

HIGHWAYS

Standard Operating Procedure (SOP)

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1. Purpose

The purpose of this Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) is to provide clear guidance to volunteers responding to reports of missing, stray, or loose dogs that are near or on roads and live carriageways. It aims to ensure that all incidents are managed in a safe, consistent, and proportionate manner, with the safety of volunteers, members of the public, and the dog being the primary consideration at all times.

This SOP establishes the principles for assessing risk, determining when it is safe to attend an incident, setting out the actions volunteers may and may not take, and identifying circumstances where incidents should be escalated to emergency services or other agencies. It also provides guidance on the use of appropriate resources, including observation and tracking methods, to support the safe management and recovery of dogs without creating additional risks to people, animals, or road users.

2. Safety First Principle

The safety of volunteers and members of the public will always take precedence over the recovery of any animal. Volunteers always retain the right to decline attendance at any incident or withdraw from any situation they believe to be unsafe.

3. Initial Scene Assessment

When a report of a loose dog is received and the dog is believed to be near or on a live carriageway, an assessment must be carried out to determine the full circumstances and environment before any action is taken.

The assessment should consider:

- The type of road (residential street, country road, dual carriageway, motorway, etc.).

- The speed limit of the road.
- The time of day and visibility conditions.
- Weather conditions.
- The dog's behaviour and current location.
- The level of traffic and any immediate risks to the public.
- The availability of volunteers and whether attendance can be carried out safely.
- The availability of other resources, including the use of drones for observation and tracking where appropriate.

The outcome of the assessment should determine whether it is safe and proportionate for volunteers to attend and what actions, if any, can be taken.

Volunteer safety must always take priority and no volunteer should place themselves at risk in an attempt to secure or recover a dog.

4. Dynamic Risk Assessment

Volunteers must continually reassess the situation throughout the incident. Changes in the dog's behaviour, location, traffic conditions, weather, visibility, or the actions of members of the public may alter the risk level and require volunteers to withdraw, escalate the incident, or adopt an alternative strategy.

5. Escalation and Contacting Police Scotland

Any dog reported on a motorway, dual carriageway, or other high-speed road should be treated as a 999 emergency incident due to the immediate risk to public safety.

Where Lost Dogs Ayrshire receives a report from a member of the public that a dog is on, or is at immediate risk of entering, a high-speed road, the caller should be encouraged to dial 999

immediately and provide Police Scotland with the most accurate and up-to-date information available.

This advice does not replace Lost Dogs Ayrshire's own responsibility to notify Police Scotland. Where appropriate, Lost Dogs Ayrshire will also contact Police Scotland to ensure the incident has been reported and to provide any additional or updated information.

When contacting Police Scotland, volunteers should provide:

- The exact location of the dog at the time of report, including the road name or number and direction of travel, if known.
- A description of the dog.
- The dog's last known direction of travel.
- Any immediate risks or hazards observed.

Volunteers should continue to monitor the situation from a place of safety and relay information to Police Scotland if requested. Under no circumstances should volunteers place themselves at risk while waiting for emergency services to attend.

6. Roads with Speed Limits of 30 mph or Less

Where a dog is reported on roads within towns, villages, or residential areas with speed limits of 30 mph or below, volunteers may be asked to attend the area to search for the dog and, where safe to do so, attempt to secure it.

The following safety measures apply:

- High-visibility clothing must be worn at all times when working near or on the road.
- Volunteers must remain aware of moving traffic and avoid placing themselves in dangerous positions.

- Volunteers should only attempt to secure the dog if it can be done safely and without causing the dog to run into traffic.
- Volunteers should never step into the road unnecessarily or put themselves at risk to secure a dog.

A change in the dog's location or behaviour, particularly where it moves towards a higher-speed road, should trigger an immediate reassessment of the incident and any planned response.

7. Roads in excess of 30 mph Speed Limits

Roads with speed limits exceeding 30 mph present a significant risk of serious injury or death to both volunteers and members of the public. A loose dog on a live carriageway may cause drivers to brake suddenly, swerve, or take evasive action, significantly increasing the risk of a serious road traffic collision.

Where a dog is reported near or on roads with speed limits above 30 mph:

- Volunteers must not stop their vehicle on a live carriageway and exit the vehicle.
- Volunteers must not attempt to capture the dog on foot.
- Volunteers must not attempt to stop, direct, or control traffic.
- Volunteers should observe only from a place of safety and provide updates on the dog's location and movements.
- Volunteers should only attend incidents where they can travel to, observe, and leave the location safely and where a safe and lawful parking location is available.
- Vehicles must only be parked in safe and lawful locations and must never stop on carriageways, hard shoulders, slip roads, or verges unless specifically directed or authorised by emergency services.

8. Traffic Management

As a community organisation, we have no legal authority to control, direct, or stop traffic on any live carriageway.

Under no circumstances should volunteers:

- Attempt to stop or direct traffic.
- Stand in the road to block vehicles.
- Use vehicles to block a carriageway.
- Place themselves in danger to prevent a dog from entering the road.
- Instruct members of the public to stop traffic on our behalf.

9. Lone Working

Lone working near roads should be avoided wherever reasonably practicable.

However, as Lost Dogs Ayrshire cannot guarantee that two or more volunteers will be available at any given time, lone working near roads may occasionally be unavoidable.

Any volunteer attending an incident alone must ensure that another volunteer or coordinator is aware of their location and intended activity. Volunteers must maintain regular contact through the organisation's approved communication channels and provide updates at appropriate intervals.

Volunteers must also notify the organisation when they are leaving the area and confirm when they have returned home, returned to work, or resumed the activity they were undertaking prior to responding to the incident.

If communication cannot be maintained, or if the volunteer feels that the risks associated with lone working have become

unacceptable, they should withdraw from the incident and reassess whether it is safe to continue.

10. Reports of Suspected Deceased Dogs on Roads

From time to time, reports may be received from members of the public or passing motorists of a suspected deceased dog on a road or live carriageway.

Due to the significant risk posed by moving traffic, volunteers will not be asked to investigate reports of suspected deceased dogs on roads, dual carriageways, or motorways.

Under no circumstances should volunteers:

- Stop on a live carriageway to investigate a report.
- Enter a carriageway to confirm whether a dog is deceased.
- Attempt to recover or move a suspected deceased dog from the road.
- Place themselves or other road users at risk.

Reports of suspected deceased dogs should be referred to the relevant local authority for safe recovery.

Local authority contact numbers:

- South Ayrshire Council – 0300 123 0900
- East Ayrshire Council – 01563 554400
- North Ayrshire Council – 01294 310000

If the animal is located on a motorway or presents an immediate danger to road users, Police Scotland should be contacted on **999**.

11. Use of Drones

Consideration may be given to the use of drones to monitor and track the movements of a loose dog, particularly where the dog is in an area that is difficult to access safely or where aerial observation may assist in maintaining visual contact without placing volunteers at risk.

The use of drones is for observation and tracking purposes only. Under no circumstances should a drone be used to:

- Herd, chase, or deliberately influence the movement of a dog.
- Drive a dog away from, or towards, any location, including roads or volunteers.
- Fly in a manner that may cause distress to the dog or create an additional risk to public safety.

Any drone operations must comply with current UK Civil Aviation Authority (CAA) regulations, including CAP 722 and the UK Drone and Model Aircraft Code, and must only be undertaken by suitably competent operators in accordance with any applicable airspace restrictions. The safety of the dog, volunteers, members of the public, and other airspace users must remain the primary consideration when deciding whether the use of a drone is appropriate.